that the inhabitants of Gujarat wore close-fitting clothes and a sarong (probably the ‘lungi’ worn by the Muslim traders). The region is described as the source of a ‘great quantities’ of indigo, red kano (a dyestuff), myrobalan, a black dyestuff, and fine cottons of different colours. The markets for these goods were both China in the east and Arab countries in the west.

At a later date, during the Yuan dynasty, the Italian traveller Marco Polo also wrote about Quanzhou, which he called Zayton, as one of the great trading ports of China. According to him, Zayton was frequented by many ships from India which brought a wide variety of spices and other rare items, including fine cotton cloth. While visiting India, Marco Polo described the port of Cambay on the Gujarat coast as a major commercial port, from where cotton buckram and indigo were exported both east and west.

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There is an important slice of medieval Indian history in which China plays a part. The Chola empire in southern India had ancient origins but reached its zenith in the period from 907 CE to 1251 CE . It was the first Indian state to maintain a large and powerful navy, and its influence was felt across South-East Asia. It had established a flourishing trade with Song China and its trading vessels frequented the ports on China’s eastern seaboard, including Guangzhou and Quanzhou. Chinese records refer to at least two ‘tribute missions’, one from Rajaraja Chola in 1014 and the other from Kulothunga Chola in 1077. The tribute presented to the Song emperor consisted of pearls, ivory, coral, glass, betel nut and cardamom. These probably represented the export basket from southern India to China in that era.

Chinese records contain the contents of the letter sent by Rajaraja Chola to his Song counterpart which the scholar Tansen Sen has translated from the Chinese. [3] Its crass obsequiousness and extravagant eulogy of the Song emperor are probably a later Chinese recasting of the original to maintain the status of the ‘Heavenly Emperor’ ruling over ‘All Under Heaven’.